

Part One

now playing: army dreamers by kate bush

One of the first things Evander learned was how to stand at attention. Not how to read or write or even ride a horse (though horses filled the stables surrounding the military housing he grew up near). Before any of those things, he learned how to stand perfectly still with his shoulders back, his chin raised and his hands clasped behind him.

His father insisted on it.

The command came from the towering figure in front of him, clad in uniform and the same rigid authority he carried with him wherever he went. Steelfang Nikadros Theron had become known throughout the kingdom as a result of his years of military campaigns and victories. However, to Evander, this man was only ever called ‘Father’. And Father was never satisfied.

No matter how many times he straightened his shoulders, or adjusted how far apart his feet were, or focused his eyes forwards, he was only ever told ‘better’.

It was relief rather than praise. Praise implied warmth, and that didn’t exist between Evander and Nikadros.

The Theron estate sat near a military stronghold on the edge of the capital. Generations of Therons had served the crown. Portraits of stern-faced officers lined the walls of the manor. Medals filled display cabinets. Stories of battlefield heroics dominated every family gathering.

There were others in the house, too.

His mother, Moira, moved through the house like a ghost. She was kind in her own way - beautiful, gentle, and warm enough to admire from afar, but far too distant to ever truly understand. As a child, Evander adored her. After difficult training sessions when bruises bloomed across his arms and his body ached from drills that no child should have endured, he would seek her out. He would sit beside her while she read by the window, enjoying the quiet presence she offered. Sometime would brush his hair from his eyes or kiss his forehead before sending him to bed. In those moments, she was the mother he desperately wanted.

However, when he asked questions, her gaze would drift elsewhere.

The answers never changed. They arrived gently, wrapped in soft words and patient smiles, but they never addressed what Evander was really asking.

There was one question she never answered though: *Why doesn't he like me?*

Eventually, he stopped asking.

While other children spent their afternoons climbing trees, racing through fields, or inventing games with friends, Evander practiced sword forms until his shoulders burned. While they scraped their knees in childish adventures, he earned bruises from wooden training weapons. By the age of eight he could disarm opponents far older than himself. By nine he could remain in the saddle for hours without complaint. By ten he could recite military doctrine from memory and identify battlefield formations from sketches alone.

No matter what he did though, none of it mattered. Every accomplishment revealed another expectation waiting. Every achievement became the new bare minimum. No matter how hard he worked, he could never reach the invisible finish line his father kept on moving further away.

The brightest point in those difficult years arrived when Evander was four years old when his younger sister was born.

Catriana changed the atmosphere of the entire household. Servants smiled more often, his mother laughed and even his father seemed almost human when he held the tiny infant in his arms. Evander still remembers standing beside the cradle and staring down at the wrinkled, red-faced baby who had somehow managed to capture everyone's attention.

From the day she was born, Catriana became his favourite person in the world.

As children they were inseparable. Evander carried her on his shoulders through the estate grounds, taught her how to climb walls when the servants weren't looking, and smuggled sweets from the kitchens to share beneath staircases and in hidden corners. He invented stories about brave knights and clever princesses who always rescued themselves, and Catriana followed him everywhere with wide-eyed fascination. For a few precious years, those memories became proof that happiness was possible. They became proof that family could mean something other than pressure, expectation, and fear.

Part Two

now playing: soldier boy by the shirelles

At eleven years old, he began noticing strange things during conversations. Arguments seemed to escalate when he was angry. People calmed down unusually quickly when he wanted them to. Teachers who had been irritated with him would soften after only a few words. Friends who were nervous before examinations sometimes left their conversations with him feeling inexplicably confident.

At first he thought it was just a coincidence.

Then things started to change.

It began with flashes. Brief moments where another person's emotions seemed to press against his own. A stable hand's anxiety before delivering bad news. A servant's homesickness for a family she hadn't seen in years. The simmering resentment of one of his father's officers after being passed over for promotion.

The experience was overwhelming. Military gatherings became exhausting; banquets filled with officers and nobles left him dizzy from the sheer volume of competing emotions pressing against him. He would retreat to empty hallways or quiet gardens simply to escape the noise.

He kept the strange experiences to himself. His father valued strength above all else, and admitting weakness felt dangerous. So he endured it alone.

Then came the sparring match.

The memory remains painfully vivid even years later. The training field was crowded with young recruits and observing officers, the afternoon sun beating down on rows of practice dummies while instructors barked corrections across the yard. Evander stood opposite another boy his age, both armed with wooden practice swords.

His opponent attacked aggressively, forcing Evander backward across the dirt. The boy was stronger than him, and faster too, each strike driving Evander further onto the defensive.

Evander felt it before he understood it: fear. A small amount at first, the ordinary nervousness that accompanied competition. The boy was worried about embarrassing himself in front of the officers watching from the sidelines.

Without thinking, Evander reached toward that fear the same way someone would reach for a falling object.

The emotion responded immediately. The fear multiplied. What had been a spark became a wildfire.

His opponent froze. The sword slipped from his fingers. His breathing quickened, and then tears filled his eyes. Within seconds the boy was sobbing uncontrollably in the middle of the training yard.

It soon came to light that Evander possessed a rare affinity: the ability to manipulate, influence and amplify emotions.

His father very quickly recognised its potential. A soldier who could spread fear through enemy ranks, strengthening loyalty. That was just the beginning of it.

His father became obsessed. The father who had once dedicated himself to molding Evander into the perfect soldier now devoted every available resource toward developing his son's affinity. Sword training remained. Physical conditioning remained. Lessons in military strategy remained. More was simply added.

Mages arrived weekly and tacticians asked increasingly immoral questions: Could he induce panic? Could he inspire obedience? Could he break morale? Could he provoke violence? Could he suppress fear? Could he influence entire groups simultaneously? Could he turn armies against themselves?

Nobody asked how it felt. Nobody asked whether he wanted any of it.

The worst part was that his mother allowed it. At first, Evander convinced himself that Moira simply did not understand what was happening. She was not a soldier, nor a mage. Perhaps she trusted the experts.

But as the years passed, that excuse became harder to believe.

She saw the exhaustion beneath his eyes. She saw the panic attacks that left him shaking. She heard the arguments between father and son echoing through the estate.

Her words of encouragement became increasingly hollow, and he eventually stopped seeking comfort from her. Not because he hated her, but because her disappointment hurt too much.

The changes in his mind were far more difficult to ignore. One morning he would wake feeling unstoppable. The world would seem bright, full of possibilities and excitement. He would train harder than anyone else, talk faster than everyone around him, and feel convinced that he could accomplish anything.

Then, without warning, everything would collapse.

A careless comment. A failed exercise. A difficult memory. Any small thing could trigger a spiral. The confidence would vanish. In its place came crushing despair, anger so intense it made his hands shake, or an emptiness that left him unable to feel anything at all.

He was told to control it. The words infuriated Evander. As though he was not trying. As though he enjoyed feeling like a storm trapped inside his own body. As though control were something simple.

His affinity gave him remarkable insight into everyone else's emotions. He could identify fear, grief, jealousy, loneliness, affection, and shame with astonishing accuracy, but his own feelings remained incomprehensible. They crashed into one another constantly, impossible to separate. The irony would have been amusing if it was not so painful.

As Evander entered his teenage years, his relationship with his family began to fracture in ways that felt both sudden and inevitable. For years he had endured his father's impossible expectations because some part of him still believed that if he worked hard enough, trained long enough, and suffered quietly enough, he would eventually earn the approval he craved.

But then, Catriana's affinity awakened. For perhaps the first time in his life, Evander witnessed his father genuinely enjoying the process of teaching a child. Nikandros guided Catriana through her training with a patience Evander had never experienced. Mistakes became opportunities for learning rather than reasons for punishment. Successes were met with praise rather than higher expectations. Their father smiled more around Catriana than Evander could ever remember him smiling around anyone.

When Catriana struggled, she received encouragement. When Evander struggled, he was told to try harder. When Catriana succeeded, Nikandros celebrated her accomplishments. When Evander succeeded, his father merely asked what came next.

The contrast became impossible to ignore.

For years Evander had chased approval like a starving man chasing scraps. He had pushed himself past exhaustion, endured endless training, and sacrificed pieces of himself in pursuit of a goal that always seemed just beyond reach.

The realization filled him with emotions he hated himself for feeling. Because he loved his sister. Catriana remained one of the few people in the estate who treated him like a person instead of a project. She still sought him out when she wanted company. She still dragged him into conversations when he isolated himself. She still defended him whenever she overheard servants or officers discussing him like some strange magical experiment. None of it was her fault.

Some days he would snap at Catriana over trivial things and immediately regret it. Other days he would avoid her entirely, retreating into training grounds or empty corners of the estate where he wouldn't have to watch their father praise her. Then guilt would consume him, and he would spend days trying to make up for behavior he could barely explain.

As the years passed, the distance between them grew despite both of their efforts. They still loved one another fiercely, but the effortless closeness of childhood became harder and harder to maintain beneath the weight of jealousy, guilt, and unspoken hurt.

His feelings toward his mother grew colder with every passing year. The younger Evander had viewed Moira as a source of comfort, a refuge from the harshness of his father's expectations. The older he became, however, the harder it was to ignore her silence.

Part Three

now playing: fable by gigi perez

The knowledge of what his affinity could do made genuine relationships feel impossible. Even when people were kind to him, a small voice in the back of his mind always whispered the same question: *Do they actually like me?* Or was he influencing them without realizing it?

He hated the uncertainty.

His power allowed him to sense emotions with frightening accuracy, but it could not tell him whether those emotions were authentic. The distinction haunted him. Every friendship felt sus. Every compliment carried doubt. Every act of kindness came with the nagging fear that perhaps it wasn't real at all.

As a result, he became increasingly withdrawn, quick-tempered, and decisive. He spent most of his time training. Or isolating himself where nobody could bother him. It was easier than trying to navigate relationships that constantly had him second-guessing himself.

Then he met him. He saw him standing outside of a bakery. Nothing remarkable. He wasn't performing magic or doing anything memorable at all. He was just standing out there.

A week later, Evander saw him again.

That time, he was helping a merchant gather spilled produce from the street after a cart wheel broke. He was laughing as he did so, entirely unconcerned with the dirt covering his hands.

Then he saw him near a river, then at a market, then outside a booksellers shop, holding far too many books beneath one arm. They shouldn't have crossed paths as many times as they did, yet they did.

At first, he thought nothing of it, then he started to notice when the boy wasn't there.

Whenever he entered a crowded street, his gaze drifted across the sea of faces around him. Whenever he visited the market, he found himself scanning the crowd. Whenever he passed familiar corners of the city, he noticed the absence before he realized he had been looking.

Then one day, he finally learned his name.

A summer storm swept through the city with little warning, dark clouds rolling overhead as merchants scrambled to cover their stalls. Rain began hammering against rooftops and cobblestones, sending people racing for shelter.

Evander ducked beneath the awning of a closed shop before the downpour began, and then *he* reached the shelter just after. Evander almost walked back out into the thunder and lightning. Either get struck by lightning or engage in conversation? Hmm.

Rather than treating him with caution or curiosity, the boy seemed almost entertained by him. There was something disarmingly straightforward about the way he regarded Evander, as though he saw past the Theron name, the military reputation, and the rare affinity that dominated every aspect of his life. The observation he made was so absurdly blunt that Evander found himself laughing before he could stop himself.

The encounter should have ended there. It should have become another insignificant memory lost among countless others. Instead, it became the beginning of something neither of them could have predicted.

Whenever their paths crossed, they stopped to talk. Then, gradually, they began arranging their days around the possibility of those meetings. At first, the interactions were brief. They discussed books, complained about the weather, shared observations about the city and the people who lived within it. The conversations themselves were utterly ordinary.

And that's what made them so perfect. His life had never been ordinary. Every interaction prior to this had been burdened by expectations or hidden motives. People usually always wanted something from him, or of him. Few ever spoke to him just because they enjoyed his company.

But this boy did. He treated Evander with ease. Military politics bored him. Discussions of magical theory held little interest unless they were genuinely interesting. When Evander finally mentioned his affinity, expecting the usual fascination, the reaction was mundane. The information was acknowledged and accepted before the conversation moved on to entirely different subjects.

It was refreshing. He was a person first, and not a weapon. Once it clicked that he was finally seen as somebody outside of just his affinity, he wanted more. More conversations, and more afternoons wandering through streets. Without realising, Evander finally found what he had been searching for his entire life.

The friendship deepened so gradually that neither of them could identify exactly when it happened. Months slipped by almost unnoticed. Shared conversations became shared afternoons. Shared afternoons became shared evenings. Eventually, entire days seemed to disappear in one another's company.

Perhaps it happened through countless small moments accumulating over time. Hands lingering together for slightly longer than necessary. Conversations stretched late into the evening because neither wanted to leave. The growing collection of private jokes and shared secrets. The realization that every particularly good day seemed to involve the other somehow.

When he realised that he had fallen in love, it was like a punch to the gut.

Love had always seemed dangerous. It was a dangerous emotion that led to many things. Anger, obsession, pain. It was one of the most vulnerable emotions and states. He'd only seen it in other people's heads. He didn't know how it worked for him. It took him a while to figure out what it felt like to him.

Their relationship remained hidden though. It had to. Nikandros controlled nearly every aspect of Evander's life, and the older Evander became, the less he trusted his father. Secrecy became a necessity rather than a choice.

But they found ways to make it work.

They discovered hidden corners of the city where nobody paid attention to them. Quiet gardens tucked behind old walls. Riverbanks that were far from crowded streets. Empty rooftops overlooking the city's lights. Places where, for a few precious hours, the rest of the world ceased to matter.

For nearly two years, those moments became Evander's sanctuary.

The turmoil inside his mind never disappeared entirely. His emotions remained volatile. His relationship with his family remained fractured. The pressures surrounding him never lessened, but it became easier. Whenever despair threatened to consume him, the self-loathing convinced him that he was impossible to love, and when anger drove him to push everyone away, the boy stayed.

Until one day, he didn't.

At first, he thought that there was an explanation. People became busy. One day passed. Then two. Then a week.

Nothing. No message or explanation or goodbye. He asked merchants and shopkeepers. Followed rumours. Returned repeatedly to places they had been to. Every lead ended the same way. It was as though the boy had vanished from the face of the world.

Was he dead? Alive? If he had died, Evander could have mourned him. If he'd abandoned him, he could have hated him. Instead he was left trapped between hope and grief.

As months passed, his mind turned towards his father. His father possessed influence, and he despised everything that distracted Evander from the future he had planned. Maybe he had intervened. Threatened the boy. Forced him to leave.

But no matter how much Evander searched, he never found any proof of anything.

His emotional instability, already difficult to manage, spiraled beyond anything he had experienced before. Training sessions ended in shouting matches. Things were broken during fits of anger. Friendships collapsed before they had a chance to form. Entire weeks vanished into sleepless nights and increasingly reckless behaviour.

Evander has tried to remember him, but things are starting to fade. First was his eyes, then his laugh and the sound of his voice, then his name. Everything faded.